

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN KOSOVO

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Kosovo's distinctive lever — making the case, on cost and health and a flawed process, that starves a big project's financing, and sustaining it until the money walks away — and it names the tools you'll meet (the EIA and approval, the international lenders, the courts and the European energy body, the persistent coalition) in plain words the first time.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

For more than a decade, successive governments planned a large new lignite power plant near Pristina — **Kosova e Re**, "New Kosovo" — to sit alongside the country's aging and notoriously polluting coal plants. It had a foreign developer on a long concession and, for years, the backing of the **World Bank**. It looked unstoppable. But a coalition of Kosovar civil-society organisations opposed it for almost a decade — on the **cost** to households and the state, on the **harm** to a population already breathing some of Europe's dirtiest air, and on a **flawed and opaque approval process**. They did not win with a single blow. They built the case, year after year, that the plant was too expensive and too dirty; that case helped move the **World Bank to withdraw its support in 2018**, and the main European development bank followed; they took the flawed environmental approval to court and to a **European energy body**; and when the economics of coal collapsed and a new government opposed the deal, the developer, unable to find new financing, finally walked away. **The plant was cancelled.**

The Kosovar civil-society coalition that killed Kosova e Re drew on a toolkit suited to a big, internationally financed project — a project that lives or dies on its financing. The **cost-and-health case** — the least-cost argument, the burden on households, the dirty air — is powerful, and it was unanswerable enough to make the project a liability. The **international lenders** (the World Bank, the European development banks) follow rules and guard reputations, and can be moved to withdraw — as the World Bank did in 2018, cutting the project's lifeline. The **courts** and the **European energy body** (the Energy Community) can be used against a flawed, opaque approval; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful. And a persistent coalition, keeping the pressure on for as long as it takes, sustains it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The cancellation was a **confluence, not a solo victory** — the campaign was real, but so were the collapsing economics of coal, the withdrawal of the lenders, and the arrival of a government opposed to the deal, and honesty requires saying so. The win was, in part, **defensive**: the new plant was stopped, but the old, dirty plants still run, and the underlying energy and air problem is unresolved. And the decisive lever — **cutting off the international financing** — worked because this project depended on international lenders, which not every project does. So don't imagine protest alone will topple a project; work to shift the economics, move the financiers, and win the political argument, so that when the moment comes the project is friendless — which is exactly what happened to Kosova e Re.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big, internationally financed project looks unstoppable, but it lives or dies on its money, and its money can be cut off. A Kosovo project of this kind needs its **EIA and approval** (challengeable if flawed); it depends on **international financing** (governed by rules you can invoke); and it can be pressed in the **courts and the**

European energy body. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and starving the financing is the one that killed Kosova e Re. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend years on this, work out your real situation:

- **If the project depends on international financing, cutting off the money is your sharpest lever** — the lenders follow rules and guard reputations.
- **If it's too expensive or too dirty, the cost-and-health case starves the financing** — the least-cost argument, the burden on households, the poisoned air.
- **If the approval was flawed or opaque, the courts and the European energy body add legal and reputational risk.**
- **If the win depends on economics and politics you don't control, work to make the project friendless** — shift the economics, move the financiers, win the political argument, and endure.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **make the case that starves the financing, challenge the flawed process, and sustain it until the money walks**, and **work to make the project friendless** — economically, financially, and politically — because these wins come as a confluence. That's how Kosova e Re was cancelled.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The **government** champions and approves the project, with an **EIA and approval** from the environment authority. But a big project depends on **international financing** — the World Bank, the European development banks — which follow **safeguard and least-cost rules** and can withdraw. The **courts** review the approval, and the **European energy body** (the Energy Community, which Kosovo belongs to) reviews compliance with energy and environmental rules. And a **new government** can oppose a deal a predecessor signed. Know which of these you can reach — and the financing is often the softest.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The EIA and approval. The project needs its approval. *Your opening:* a **flawed or opaque approval** — pushed through without proper consultation — is challengeable, and adds legal and reputational risk.

The financing. The project needs its **international lenders**. *Your opening — the decisive one:* make the cost-and-health-and-process case that moves the lenders to withdraw.

The economics and politics. *Your opening:* shift the economics (renewables cheaper than coal), and win the political argument, so a new government or the market abandons it.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things — and here, follow the money literally. **Who finances it** — the international lenders, whose rules and reputations you can invoke. **What case cuts the financing** — that it's not the least-cost option, that it burdens households, that it poisons the air, that the approval was flawed. **What it still needs** — the financing not secured, the approval under challenge, the political backing slipping: whatever's missing is the soft spot.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **international lenders** follow safeguard and least-cost rules and can withdraw. The **courts** and the **European energy body** review the approval and compliance. The **environment authority** runs the EIA. And Kosovo's **civil-society organisations, energy and environmental experts, and a free press** are the forces that reach furthest — the persistent coalition that killed Kosova e Re.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether the project depends on cuttable financing, whether the cost-and-health case is strong, and whether you can endure.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the EIA	15–35%	during approval	low	On record; a ground for challenge
Build the cost-and-health case	30–55%	months–yr	low	The least-cost/health argument that moves money
Challenge the flawed approval (courts / energy body)	30–55%	months–2 yr	mod	Legal and reputational risk added
Move the international lenders to withdraw	40–65%	years	low	The financing lifeline cut (Kosova e Re)
Persistent coalition	(enabling)	years	low	The pressure sustained for as long as it takes
Shift the economics / win the politics	30–55%	years	low	The project left friendless
Everything together (financed project, case + endurance)	45–70%	years	mod	The money walks; the project cancelled
Everything together (project not lender-dependent)	20–45%	years	mod	Delayed; contested; harder

The lever that moves the needle most is **cutting off the international financing** — by making the cost-and-health-and-process case that the lenders' own rules must heed — sustained by a persistent coalition. Kosova e Re shows the ceiling (a championed plant cancelled) and the honest floor (a confluence, partly defensive, dependent on cuttable financing). So aim for the financing cut, the approval challenged, delay, and a project left friendless — and endure.

On cost: the case, the documents, and the coalition are cheap; the financing lever costs nothing but the work of building an unanswerable case; the strength is expertise and endurance, not money. The great requirement is to make the project friendless — economically, financially, and politically — and to sustain that for years.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this financing, this least-cost argument, this flawed approval — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who finances it? Name the project, the developer, and — crucially — the **international lenders** it depends on.

2. What is the cost-and-health case? Is it more expensive than the alternatives (not the least-cost option)? Does it burden households and the budget? Does it poison the air? **The cost-and-health case is what starves the financing.**

3. Was the approval flawed or opaque? Pushed through without proper consultation, on a thin EIA? That flaw adds legal and reputational risk the lenders must weigh.

4. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is the financing being sought? The approval under challenge? A milestone due? These openings are time-bound.

5. Who's your coalition, and can you endure? Civil-society organisations, energy and environmental experts, a free press. Kosova e Re was killed by a coalition that fought for a decade.

What this looks like in real life. A government champions a big coal plant, financed by international lenders, on a flawed approval, in a country with dirty air. The five questions yield: a developer and its lenders (the target); a cost-and-health case (the financing lever); a flawed approval (the legal risk); financing being sought; and a coalition that can endure. That's the Kosova e Re pattern — make the case that starves the money, challenge the process, and sustain it.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — and the decisive proof here is the cost-and-health case. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the cost-and-health case. Build the **unanswerable case** that the project is not the least-cost option (renewables cheaper), that its guaranteed price and state guarantees will burden households and the budget for decades, and that it will poison an airshed. Marshal the economics and the health science — this is what moves the lenders.

Layer two: the flawed process. Document the **flaws in the approval** — the EIA pushed through without proper consultation, the opacity — which add the legal and reputational risk the lenders must weigh, and which ground a court and energy-body challenge.

Layer three: the financing map. Map the **financing** — which international lenders the project depends on, and what rules (least-cost, safeguards, reputation) each must follow — so you know whose standards to turn against the project. Walking into the lenders, the courts, or the European energy body with the cost-and-health case, the flawed process, and that financing map is what cuts the lifeline.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The cost-and-health case** — the least-cost comparison, the burden on households, the air-pollution and health science.
- **The EIA, the approval, the consultation record** — and their flaws — from the environment authority.

- **The financing map** — which lenders, and what rules each follows.
- **The concession and guarantees** — the price and state guarantees that burden the budget.
- **Expert analysis** — energy economics and health, the backbone of the case.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a persistent, expert coalition aimed at the money gives you power — the Kosova e Re model. Build in four moves.

Build a persistent, expert coalition. Kosova e Re was killed by a coalition of civil-society organisations that fought for nearly a decade, with real energy and economic expertise. Build that broad, expert, enduring coalition — the case that moves lenders must be credible and sustained.

Aim the case at the money, not just the public. The distinctive insight: aim your case **at the financing**. A big project lives or dies on its lenders, and the lenders follow rules and guard reputations. Build the cost-and-health-and-process case that turns those rules against the project.

Challenge the flawed process — for the legal risk. Take the flawed, opaque approval to the **courts** and the **European energy body**, adding the legal and reputational risk that makes lenders wary.

Build to last, and work the economics and politics. Kosovo fights of this kind run for years. Build clear roles, a secure archive, a way to decide together, a plan for the long toll — and work to **shift the economics** (renewables cheaper) and **win the political argument**, so that when the moment comes the project is friendless.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES & THE FINANCING LEVER

Kosovo's sharpest lever is starving the financing, backed by the courts and the European energy body.

Cut Off the Financing — the Decisive Lever

The route that killed Kosova e Re: aim the **cost-and-health-and-process case** at the **international lenders**, whose rules (least-cost, safeguards) and reputations you can turn against the project. Make the unanswerable case that the project is not the least-cost option, that it burdens households, that it poisons the air, and that its flawed approval carries legal and reputational risk — and move the lenders to **withdraw**, cutting the lifeline. This is Kosovo's most powerful and distinctive lever, where a project depends on cuttable financing.

The Flawed Approval — the Courts and the Energy Body

Challenge a **flawed or opaque approval** — one pushed through without proper consultation — in the **courts** and before the **European energy body** (the Energy Community), adding the legal and reputational risk that makes lenders and governments wary and buys time.

The Economics and the Politics

Work to **shift the economics** (renewables cheaper than coal) and **win the political argument**, so a new government or the market abandons the project. The financing walks most easily when the project is already friendless.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the financing lever is powerful, but the win is often a **confluence** with economics and politics you don't fully control, it can be **defensive** (the old harm remains), and it works only where the project depends on **cuttable financing**. So use the strong tools — the cost-and-health case, the financing lever, the courts and energy body, the persistent coalition — work the economics and politics, and count the financing cut, the approval challenged, delay, and a project left friendless as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Cost becomes a lender's problem. Not "we oppose the plant" but *"this is not the least-cost option — renewables are cheaper, and your rules require you to heed that,"* aimed at the lenders.

Health becomes a reputational risk. *"This poisons an airshed already among Europe's dirtiest — a reputational risk no development bank should carry."*

A flawed approval becomes a legal risk. *"The approval was pushed through without proper consultation — a legal and reputational risk to the project and its backers."*

The economics become the ending. *"Coal's economics have collapsed — this project is friendless, and its money is walking."*

Match it to the venue: the cost-and-health case to the lenders; the flawed approval to the courts and the energy body; the reputational risk to the lenders and the press; the economics to the market and the politics.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Kosovo, attention that reaches the lenders and the international arena is a decisive lever — a cost-and-health case, amplified internationally, moves the financiers who hold the project's lifeline. A free press makes the media front central.

Lead with the cost and the dirty air, not procedure. Not "the approval was flawed" but "a plant too expensive and too dirty, to be built with international money in the dirtiest air in Europe." Use your strongest material: the least-cost comparison, the health and air science, and any lender withdrawal or court progress banked.

Work several audiences at once — reach the lenders and the world. Local press builds the domestic and political pressure; international coverage reaches the lenders and the European bodies, where the financing lever bites. Make it easy: clear summaries of the economics and health, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything, especially on the economics and health science that the lenders will scrutinise. And keep the coalition's expert credibility, because a credible case is what moves money.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Information request (to the authority).

Subject: Request for the approval and financing — [project].

"We, [coalition/residents] of [place], request the EIA, the approval, the concession and guarantees, and the financing arrangements for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the EIA / approval.

Subject: Objection — [project].

"We, [coalition/residents] of [place], object to [project]: [it is not the least-cost option; it burdens households; it poisons our air; the approval was flawed and opaque]. We ask that it be refused. [Attach the case.]"

8C — To the international lenders.

Subject: [Project] is not the least-cost option — please do not finance it.

"We, [coalition] of [place], ask you not to finance [project]. It is not the least-cost option [the evidence]; it burdens households; it poisons an airshed among Europe's dirtiest; and its approval was flawed. Your rules and reputation require you to heed this. [Attach the case.]"

8D — Challenge to the European energy body.

Subject: Compliance concern — [project], Kosovo.

"We report that [project]'s approval breaches [energy/environmental rules]: [specifics]. We ask the Energy Community to review it. [Attach evidence.]"

8E — To a lawyer (court challenge).

Subject: Challenge — [project] approval.

"Our community faces [project], approved on a flawed and opaque process. We've gathered [the case, the approval flaws]. We ask your advice on challenging it. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the developer.

Subject: Financial, legal, and reputational risk in [project].

"We are the coalition opposing [project] at [location]. It is not the least-cost option, its approval is flawed, and its financing is at risk. As with Kosova e Re, this makes the venture friendless. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press (national and international).

Subject: [Coalition] moves to stop [project] — too costly and too dirty.

"[Project] would be built with international money, too expensive and too dirty, in [the dirtiest air in Europe]. We can provide the economics, the health science, and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the coalition.

Subject: We can starve this project — here's how.

"[Project] the government champions lives or dies on its financing. At Kosova e Re, a coalition made the case — on cost, health, and a flawed process — that cut off the money, and killed the plant. If we build that

case, reach the lenders, and endure, we can too. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Build the cost-and-health case — not the least-cost option, burdens households, poisons the air.** That's what starves the financing.
2. **Map the financing, and take the case to the lenders (8C).**
3. **Document the flawed approval, and object (8B).**
4. **Challenge the flawed approval in the courts and the European energy body (8D/8E).**
5. **Reach the international press to amplify the case to the lenders (8G).**
6. **Build a persistent coalition (8H), work the economics and politics, and endure.**

Even lean, those six make the case that starves the financing, add the legal risk, and sustain it — the Kosova e Re template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Kosovo's tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When the government champions the project. Don't attack it head-on alone: aim at the financing, add the legal risk, and win the political argument, so the project loses its money and its friends.

When the win is a confluence. Kosova e Re died from many causes together. Work to shift the economics, move the financiers, and win the politics, so that when the moment comes the project is friendless — don't imagine protest alone will topple it.

When the win is defensive. The new plant was stopped, but the old ones run. Keep pressing on the underlying energy and air problem beyond the single project.

When the project isn't lender-dependent. The financing lever needs a project that depends on cuttable money. Where it doesn't, lean harder on the courts, the process, and the public.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Kosovo has real concerns about opaque energy deals and the capture of big projects, so this matters.

How to spot it. Approvals pushed through without consultation; concessions and guarantees on opaque terms; the least-cost rule ignored; benefits to the connected while households pay and the air poisons.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Auditor General** and the anti-corruption agency examine public money and conduct. The **courts** and the **European energy body** review the approval. The **international lenders'** own accountability mechanisms review safeguard breaches. And Kosovo's **civil society and press** have exposed captured deals.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the flawed approval, the opaque guarantees, who benefits, what the rules required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you

suspect. Route serious evidence to the Auditor General, the anti-corruption agency, the courts, the energy body, the lenders' accountability mechanisms, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the financing lever.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, over the long haul. The cost-and-health case starves the financing; the flawed process adds the legal risk; the coalition sustains it; the courts and energy body press it; the economics and politics leave the project friendless; the press reaches the lenders. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall.

Early on (weeks–months): build the cost-and-health case; map the financing; object in the EIA; document the flawed approval; build a persistent, expert coalition.

In the thick of it (months–years): take the case to the lenders; challenge the approval in the courts and the energy body; work the economics and politics; open the international media front.

The long haul (years): sustain the pressure until the financing walks; keep the coalition enduring; leave the project friendless; hold the line for the financing cut, the approval challenged, delay, and a project cancelled.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a big, financed project in Kosovo can be done — a civil-society coalition helped kill a coal plant the government had championed for a decade, above all by cutting off its money. Hold both truths. Kosovo's distinctive power is real: a persistent coalition can stop a big, internationally financed project by making the case — on cost, on health, on a flawed process — that turns the lenders' own rules and reputations against it and cuts off its financing. And the constraints are real: the win is a confluence with economics and politics you don't fully control; it can be defensive, leaving the old harm; and the financing lever works only where a project depends on cuttable money.

Here's the discipline that wins. Build the unanswerable cost-and-health case — that the project is not the least-cost option, that it burdens households, that it poisons the air — and aim it not only at the public but at the **money**, turning the international lenders' own rules and reputations against the project until they withdraw. Challenge the flawed, opaque approval in the courts and the European energy body, adding the legal and reputational risk that makes financiers wary. Work to shift the economics and win the political argument, so that when the moment comes the project is friendless. And sustain it all through a persistent, expert coalition, for as long as it takes. Count the financing cut, the approval challenged, delay, and a project cancelled as wins. That's how Kosova e Re was starved — the cost-and-health case, the financing lever, the flawed process, and a decade of endurance together. So can you.